

CORE FORMULA

Shared point + modest signal + evidence + return of focus. -> "I recognise that part too, at least the timeline piece. How has that been showing up for you?" -> **Professional:** "We are dealing with the same constraint - unclear priorities. The clean next step would be one owner per task. Does that match what you are seeing?" -> **High-pressure:** "We may not agree on every detail, but I think we share the concern about rework. Can we anchor there for the next five minutes?" -> **Minimum:** "I recognise that part. What has it been like on your side?"

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

I recognise that part. What has it been like on your side?

BEST FOR

- Early rapport when there is one visible shared point
- Tense conversations where a small shared concern can lower defensiveness
- Professional collaboration where shared constraints matter
- Social settings where the other person is unsure whether you understand the context
- Digital messages where tone could otherwise read as cold
- Bridging role, age, seniority, or background differences without pretending sameness

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers · Short, one-line signals

- "I recognise that part. What has it been like on your side?"
- "Same here - what was yours like?"
- "Different situation, but that one piece is familiar."
- "I have a small version of that too."
- "Same on that. What changed this time?"
- "That tracks - I have run into the same thing."

Low-key social · Warm, everyday overlap

- "I recognise that part. My version was not identical, but the uncertainty piece is familiar."
- "I have a small version of that too. What was yours like?"
- "Same here on the preference for clear plans."
- "That makes sense to me. I have run into the same thing."
- "I have had a version of that new-city recalibration. What has been the easiest part so far?"
- "Different situation, but I recognise the uncertainty piece. What has been weighing on you most?"

Professional · Shared constraints and goals

- "We are probably facing the same constraint: unclear priorities."
- "I think we are aligned on the underlying goal: reduce rework."
- "Same concern on my side - I want the output clear without slowing the team down."
- "I recognise the trade-off you are naming. I am balancing that too."
- "We may have different roles, but the pressure point looks similar."
- "Same constraint here: too many priority labels. What would make the next step clearer for you?"
- "We share the goal of keeping the process predictable. I will keep the next steps explicit."

Digital / async · Warming up a written thread

- "Same concern here: unclear ownership."

- "I am aligned on keeping this simple and visible."
- "I recognise that pattern - here is my read, though I may be missing context."
- "Similar preference on my end: keep it simple and visible."
- "Same preference here: clear, simple, no hidden steps. I suggest we list the owner and the deadline."
- "I am aligned on the goal. The open question for me is the timing."

Disagreement / pressure · One shared anchor amid conflict

- "We disagree on the route, but I think we share the concern about avoiding rework."
- "I do not want to overstate agreement. The similarity I do see is the deadline pressure."
- "There is at least one shared constraint here: the deadline. Can we start there?"
- "I hear the same risk from a different angle."
- "We may not agree on every detail, but I think we share this concern. Can we anchor there?"
- "We do not agree on the method, but we do share the concern about quality."

Difference-protecting · Naming the overlap without erasing the difference

- "Different situations, clearly. I only meant the small uncertainty piece."
- "We seem to share a preference for clear expectations."
- "Let me not overclaim it - the part I recognise is the moving brief."
- "Different situations, but I recognise that one constraint."
- "We share the deadline pressure. Let us anchor on the one decision that reduces it."
- "I recognise one part of that, not the whole thing."

Repair · When the signal lands as self-focus

- "I may have made that too much about my version. Back to yours."
- "Different situations, clearly. Let me come back to what you were saying."
- "Let me not overclaim the similarity. What I meant was only the timeline part."
- "That may not be the right comparison. I will drop it."
- "Thanks for correcting that - I had the wrong read."
- "I do not want to force a connection that is not there."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Me too. I know exactly what you mean.

Better: I have had something similar with vague timelines. It can make the whole thing harder to plan.

Best: I recognise the vague-timeline part. My situation was different, but that uncertainty piece is familiar. What has made it hardest on your side?

2. Weak: Same.

Better: Same on the unclear-timeline part.

Best: Same on the unclear-timeline part. What has been the main friction for you?

3. Weak: We are basically the same.

Better: Different situations, but I recognise that one constraint.

Best: We share the deadline pressure. Let us anchor on the one decision that reduces it.

DECISION TREE

If No real overlap is present

Do not force it. Listen, reflect, or look for common ground before signalling anything.

"What has that been like for you?"

If The overlap is real but not specific or safe to name

Keep listening or ask a clean question first.

"What part has been the hardest?"

If Naming it could minimise, compete with, or hijack their experience

Shrink the signal or skip it, and protect their difference.

"Different situation, but I recognise that one piece."

If The overlap is real, specific, and safe

Signal it once, ground it in a single detail, then return the focus.

"I recognise that part, at least the timeline piece. What has it been like on your side?"

If They open up after the signal

Continue gently with a question or a shared next step.

"What would make the next step clearer for you?"

If They go flat, correct you, or seem uncomfortable

Return to their point, narrow the claim, or drop it - do not stack a second signal.

"Back to you - what has been weighing most?"

SCENARIOS

Professional collaboration - a teammate is frustrated by unclear priorities

Signal the shared constraint, then return to action. — "Same constraint here: too many priority labels. What would make the next step clearer for you?"

New social setting - someone mentions being new to the city

Signal a small, non-possessive overlap and hand it back. — "I have had a version of that new-city recalibration. What has been the easiest part so far?"

Disagreement - you differ on the route but share a concern

Preserve the disagreement while naming the one overlap. — "We do not agree on the method, but I think we share the concern about avoiding rework. Can we anchor there?"

Supportive listening - someone describes a stressful transition

Use only a tiny signal, then listen. — "Different situation, but I recognise the uncertainty piece. What has been weighing on you most?"

Digital message - a written exchange is turning stiff

Add a concise similarity signal to reduce distance, then propose one step. — "Same preference here: clear, simple, no hidden steps. I suggest we list the owner and the deadline."

Boundary-sensitive context - a formal client or colleague

Use task-relevant similarity only. — "We share the goal of keeping the process predictable. I will keep the next steps explicit."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- You would have to invent or exaggerate the similarity.
- They are sharing something painful and need listening more than affiliation.
- The similarity would minimise or flatten their experience.
- The context calls for boundaries or formality, not closeness.
- You would be using the signal to gain compliance or agreement.
- They have already shown disinterest, discomfort, or a preference for distance.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the overlap

Take five ordinary statements you hear today and, for each, identify exactly one real overlap. Write it down and say nothing yet - the aim is to train the eye for a genuine shared point, not to perform it.

Day 2 — One-sentence signals

For each overlap from Day 1, write a single sentence that names it without taking over. Example: "Same on the last-minute-change part. What changed this time?"

Day 3 — Protect the difference

Rewrite three heavy claims - "I know exactly what you mean", "We are basically the same" - into difference-protecting versions such as "Different situation, but I recognise the uncertainty piece."

Day 4 — Return the focus

Take each signal from Day 2 and add a return question or shared next step, so attention lands back on them: "...What has been the main friction for you?"

Day 5 — No self-story rep

In one real conversation, use exactly one similarity signal, hold yourself to a single sentence of your own evidence, then hand it back and stop.

Day 6 — Score yourself

After each attempt today, score 0-3 (0 = invented or exaggerated, 1 = true but self-focused, 2 = true, brief, specific, 3 = also returned focus cleanly). Aim for consistent 3s.

Day 7 — Read the landing

Use one signal in a harder setting - a mild disagreement or a formal contact. Watch whether they soften, correct, or pull away, and narrow or drop the claim accordingly.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Was the similarity real and specific?
- Did I keep it modest and preserve their difference?
- Did I return focus to them, the task, or the shared next step?
- Did the signal create ease, or ask them to manage me?
- Did I avoid using it to pressure, sell, or override their autonomy?
- What would the smaller version be next time?